

The interview loop end to end

Week 7, Lecture 2 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- The phone screen: what it tests and how to pass it
- Virtual on-site structure: what each round is for
- How interviewers calibrate scores inside a loop
- The debrief process: what happens after you leave
- What the hiring committee reads and decides

By the end of this lecture you can describe the full loop from recruiter call to offer decision and explain what is happening inside the company at each step.

Part 1: the phone screen

The phone screen is a filter, not an evaluation

- Goal: confirm the candidate is plausible for the role, not rank them against the field
- Typical formats: 30-45 minutes, one interviewer, one coding problem or a few behavioral questions
- The screen is pass/fail: move to on-site or do not
- The interviewer is often a recruiter or a junior engineer with a checklist

Pass the screen by being clear, concrete, and not surprising anyone.

What kills candidates at the phone screen

- Silence: not talking through reasoning leaves the interviewer with nothing to score
- Over-engineering: proposing a distributed solution to a sorting problem signals misread of context
- Underqualification signals: claiming familiarity with tools you cannot discuss at a basic level
- Failure to clarify: accepting an ambiguous problem statement and solving the wrong problem

Orosz (2020): "Many tech interview preparation books almost exclusively focus on the coding side... this is far from enough."

Part 2: virtual on-site structure

The on-site is three to five rounds in sequence

- Typical new-grad on-site: two coding rounds, one system design, one behavioral
- Some companies add a "bar raiser" round or a second behavioral
- Each round is 45-60 minutes with a different interviewer who does not know how the other rounds went
- The rounds are designed to be independent: a weak coding round should not contaminate the behavioral score

Total elapsed time: 3-5 hours including breaks.

What each round is actually measuring

Round	Primary signal
Coding (x2)	Problem solving, code quality, communication under pressure
System design	Ability to reason about tradeoffs at scale
Behavioral	Evidence of leadership principle behaviors in past work
Bar raiser	Cross-company bar: would this person raise the average?

Prepare each round separately. The skills that make you pass coding do not transfer to system design.

Interviewer independence is by design

- Interviewers are told not to discuss their scores until the debrief
- This prevents anchoring: if the first interviewer says "strong hire," later interviewers may unconsciously match
- In practice, calibration happens at the debrief, not during the loop
- This means a bad first round does not automatically sink you -- but it will be visible in the packet

Show up fresh for every round. The reset is real.

Part 3: how interviewers calibrate

The feedback packet is the real artifact

- After your interview, the interviewer writes a packet: questions asked, your verbatim answers, a vote (strong hire, hire, no hire, strong no hire), and a written justification
- The vote alone is not enough: the written justification is what the debrief reads
- A "hire" with a weak justification ("answered well, seemed smart") carries less weight than a "hire" with specific evidence
- Strong-hire votes with specific quotes move committees

Orosz (2023): the hiring committee reads every feedback packet before anyone says a word.

The calibration problem

- Different interviewers have different bars: some are aggressive graders, some inflate
- The debrief process corrects for this by reading actual evidence, not just votes
- This is why "we" stories fail: the committee cannot calibrate evidence they cannot verify
- A story with a named decision, a named outcome, and a named number is easy to score; a story with impressions and vibes is not

Specificity is not just good storytelling. It is what makes your story scoreable.

Part 4: the debrief and hiring committee

What happens in the debrief

- All interviewers convene (sometimes asynchronously via a shared doc) to discuss the candidate
- The bar raiser, if present, has veto authority
- The recruiter is usually present but does not vote
- Discussion follows this sequence: each interviewer reads their written notes, then the group debates conflicting votes

Spolsky (2006): "If you have any doubts whatsoever, do not hire."

What the hiring committee reads

- Full feedback packets from every interviewer
- Resume as context for validating story claims
- Sometimes: take-home assignment results, portfolio links, or a recruiter note on communication
- The committee is looking for one thing: is there a pattern of evidence across multiple rounds?

One strong round cannot rescue four weak ones. One weak round rarely kills a strong pattern.

What the candidate never sees

- The written justifications
- Which interviewers voted hire versus no hire
- Whether a bar raiser override happened
- The calibration discussion

You can ask the recruiter for feedback after a rejection. You will usually get a summary, not the raw packets.

Many tech interview preparation books almost exclusively focus on the coding side of things... this is far from enough.

<footer>Gergely Orosz, "The Tech Interview Inside Out," 2020</footer>

Take-aways

1. The phone screen is pass/fail. Pass it by being clear, concrete, and communicating your reasoning aloud.
2. Each on-site round is scored independently. A weak round is visible in the packet but does not automatically end your candidacy.
3. Interviewers write feedback packets with specific evidence, not just votes. The committee reads every word.
4. The debrief corrects for individual calibration differences by comparing written evidence across rounds.
5. The bar raiser exists to enforce a company-wide standard that overrules headcount pressure.

What's next

- **Section (this week):** STAR story bank workshop -- write 12 stories, peer-review three under timed conditions
- **Reading (this week):** Week 7 reading covers STAR structure in depth with a full worked example
- **HW 3:** Due this week (recorded mock coding interview)
- **HW 5:** Out this week -- STAR story bank (12 stories)
- **Capstone:** Out this week -- application sprint, full mock loop, one unconventional move
- **Week 8:** Unconventional paths -- open source, unpaid stints, find-a-problem moves